prevent the emergence of a new nuclear showdown, or at least resolve it without a nuclear war, by reexamining the history of the crisis? In this book I argue that there is indeed much to be learned from the experience of those who created and then resolved the crisis. There is an additional reason to revisit that history. With the world sliding back into the nuclear brinkmanship that characterized the 1950s and early 1960s, it is essential to educate new generations about the dramatic events of that era in a way that addresses the uncertainties of today's world.

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THE BODY OF LITERATURE ON THE HISTORY OF THE CUBAN MISSILE crisis is truly enormous, but as I show below there are major gaps both in the coverage of the crisis and in understanding it as an international rather than a solely American affair. The deep dive into the history of the crisis began in the 1960s with Robert Kennedy's *Thirteen Days: A Memoir of the Cuban Missile Crisis*. It remains very popular with readers. But the appearance in the public domain of tapes of the ExCom* debates, made secretly by President Kennedy and apparently available to his brother when he was working on his book, challenged many established "truths" about the process of decision-making. Later research showed that his account was often self-serving and inaccurate with regard to the role played in the crisis by Robert Kennedy's nemeses and rivals, such as Secretary of State Dean Rusk and then vice president Lyndon Johnson.[4]

Major progress has been made by historians, political scientists, and journalists since the publication of Robert Kennedy's book in 1971. The classic work of the Harvard historian Graham Allison (later joined by Philip Zelikow) on decision-making during the crisis became a must-read for generations of international relations students throughout the world. The work done in the 1990s by the American historian Timothy Naftali and his Russian colleague Aleksandr Fursenko contributed enormously to our understanding of the decision-making process in Moscow, while an excellent journalistic investigation by Michael Dobbs presented the bottom-up story of the crisis, which involved dozens if not hundreds of thousands